

Butterfly Milkweed

Asclepias tuberosa

Butterfly Weed · Pleurisy Root



QUALITIES

A clumping prairie milkweed 1 to 2 feet tall, with narrow alternate leaves on hairy upright stems. From June into August it produces vibrant clusters of five-pointed orange flowers — the most saturated orange in the native flora — followed by typical milkweed spindle-shaped pods that split to release silk-tufted seeds. Unlike most milkweeds it does *not* exude white latex when broken — the sap is clear, hence the genus name *tuberosa* meaning "with tuberous root."

CARE

Full sun, well-drained soil; ideal for sand or sandy loam. Drought-tolerant. Deer-resistant. The deep taproot makes Butterfly Milkweed nearly impossible to transplant — plant once, leave alone. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Slow to emerge in spring (mark its location with a stake the first year so you don't accidentally weed it). Long-lived once established.

HISTORY

Butterfly milkweed's other common name, "pleurisy root," reflects its widespread historical use among Indigenous peoples and 19th-century herbalists for respiratory illness — the Choctaw, Omaha, Ponca, and Dakota used a root preparation. The bright orange dye from the flowers and stems was used in basketwork. European observers noted the plant as one of the most visually striking of North American natives, and it has been in cultivation since the 1690s.

REASON TO BE

Butterfly milkweed is one of three *Asclepias* species that serve as primary host plants for the Monarch butterfly — without milkweed, no Monarchs. Its summer bloom is also a magnet for Eastern Tiger Swallowtails, Fritillaries, and dozens of native bee species. The saturated orange is so visually striking it provides the design's color punctuation. Plant in drifts of 5 or more for visual mass and pollinator-attraction amplification.